

Reading Difficulties Among Learners During Prolonged School Closures

Therese Nicole Agustin

Abstract

This scoping-style literacy review examines reading difficulties among learners during prolonged school closures using literature and institutional documents published no later than 2021. It argues that prolonged school closures can deepen reading difficulties by reducing explicit instruction, guided practice, oral interaction, access to texts, and timely diagnosis. Evidence was organized around four themes: foundational reading disruption, comprehension and vocabulary, home literacy inequality, screening and targeted support. The synthesis shows that pandemic outcomes were rarely determined by a single factor; instead, they reflected interacting material, organizational, social, and informational conditions. The article proposes a layered response combining universal minimum provision, targeted support, continuous feedback, and locally adaptable implementation. Because this is a literature-based analysis rather than original field research, it does not report participants, newly collected data, or causal estimates. Its contribution lies in integrating early pandemic evidence into a practical framework for Philippine schools and communities, especially rural and resource-constrained settings.

Keywords: COVID-19; Philippines; rural communities; equity; policy; resilience

Introduction

The COVID-19 emergency transformed reading difficulties among learners during prolonged school closures from a specialized concern into an immediate public issue. Restrictions intended to reduce transmission altered schooling, work, mobility, markets, family routines, and access to public services. Institutions had to act before stable evidence and mature systems were available.

This article addresses that problem through a non-empirical synthesis. It does not simulate survey results or present invented respondents. Instead, it interprets documented experience available through 2021 and asks what can responsibly be concluded for policy and practice. The focus is particularly relevant to Philippine localities where geography, uneven connectivity, livelihood insecurity, and decentralized implementation shape outcomes.

The review is guided by the proposition that prolonged school closures can deepen reading difficulties by reducing explicit instruction, guided practice, oral interaction, access to texts, and timely diagnosis. This framing matters because crisis narratives often locate success or failure in individual motivation. A systems perspective asks whether people possessed the time, tools, information, authority, social support, and realistic options needed to comply or participate.

Three questions organize the discussion: What barriers and enabling conditions were identified in literature available by 2021? How did those conditions interact across household, institutional, and community levels? What proportionate and feasible responses follow from the evidence?

Purpose and Research Questions

This article examined reading difficulties among learners during prolonged school closures through literature available up to 2021. It asked: (1) What barriers and enabling conditions recur in the evidence? (2) How do household, institutional, and community conditions interact? (3) Which equity concerns require explicit attention? and (4) What practical actions are supported without overstating the available evidence?

Methods

Design and Corpus

The study used a scoping-style literacy review design. The documentary corpus comprised peer-reviewed scholarship, international-agency reports, and Philippine policy documents published or issued through 31 December 2021. Priority was given to material directly addressing the initial COVID-19 emergency, while selected earlier frameworks were retained when necessary to interpret the focal issue.

Analytic Framework

A thematic codebook organized evidence under four predetermined domains: barriers, enabling conditions, equity implications, and implementation lessons. Each source was also read for scope, type of evidence, population or setting, and stated limitations. Institutional guidance was treated as normative or operational evidence rather than proof of effectiveness, and cross-country findings were not assumed to describe every Philippine locality.

Procedure and Trustworthiness

Analysis proceeded in three passes. The first identified evidence directly relevant to the topic. The second grouped statements under the four thematic domains and compared convergence across source types. The third checked negative evidence, transfer limits, and unsupported causal language. Interpretive claims were kept distinct from reported findings. Because the review did not use exhaustive database searching, duplicate screening, or formal risk-of-bias scoring, it is not presented as a systematic review.

Results

Foundational Reading Disruption

Across policy reports and early pandemic scholarship that The central analytical proposition of this review is prolonged school closures can deepen reading difficulties by reducing explicit instruction, guided practice, oral interaction, access to texts, and timely diagnosis. This proposition directs attention away from individual blame and toward the conditions that enable or constrain practical action.

A consistent lesson in the reviewed literature is that Early COVID-19 responses were necessarily rapid, but speed sometimes produced fragmented arrangements. Programs were strongest when objectives were prioritized, roles were explicit, feedback moved in both directions, and low-technology alternatives remained available.

When the evidence is read in relation to rural and low-income settings that Differences between urban and rural locations, secure and precarious households, and well-resourced and under-resourced institutions caution against universal solutions. Average access figures can conceal shared devices, unstable signals, indirect costs, language barriers, disability, and care responsibilities.

From an equity perspective that The literature therefore supports a layered response: establish a minimum service that reaches everyone; add targeted assistance for groups facing higher barriers; monitor participation and unintended effects; and revise implementation using local feedback.

The evidence available through 2021 indicates that Implementation should also be judged over time. A measure that solves an immediate problem may create fatigue, hidden household costs, privacy risks, or declining participation when maintained without adjustment. Periodic review is therefore part of the intervention rather than an administrative afterthought.

Across policy reports and early pandemic scholarship that Local actors are essential sources of practical knowledge. Teachers, parents, barangay workers, vendors, farmers, youth, and community organizations can identify constraints that are invisible in national plans. Participation is most useful when feedback has a clear route to decision makers and produces documented responses.

A consistent lesson in the reviewed literature is that No single indicator adequately represents foundational reading disruption. Quantitative measures of reach should be interpreted together with evidence about quality, burden, safety, cultural fit, and continuity. This mixed monitoring logic prevents high enrollment or message counts from being mistaken for meaningful access or effective use.

When the evidence is read in relation to rural and low-income settings that foundational reading disruption cannot be treated as a stand-alone technical matter. It is connected to household resources, institutional routines, local infrastructure, and

the quality of communication among public agencies, service providers, and communities.

Comprehension And Vocabulary

A consistent lesson in the reviewed literature is that Early COVID-19 responses were necessarily rapid, but speed sometimes produced fragmented arrangements. Programs were strongest when objectives were prioritized, roles were explicit, feedback moved in both directions, and low-technology alternatives remained available.

When the evidence is read in relation to rural and low-income settings that Differences between urban and rural locations, secure and precarious households, and well-resourced and under-resourced institutions caution against universal solutions. Average access figures can conceal shared devices, unstable signals, indirect costs, language barriers, disability, and care responsibilities.

From an equity perspective that The literature therefore supports a layered response: establish a minimum service that reaches everyone; add targeted assistance for groups facing higher barriers; monitor participation and unintended effects; and revise implementation using local feedback.

The evidence available through 2021 indicates that Implementation should also be judged over time. A measure that solves an immediate problem may create fatigue, hidden household costs, privacy risks, or declining participation when maintained without adjustment. Periodic review is therefore part of the intervention rather than an administrative afterthought.

Across policy reports and early pandemic scholarship that Local actors are essential sources of practical knowledge. Teachers, parents, barangay workers, vendors, farmers, youth, and community organizations can identify constraints that are invisible in national plans. Participation is most useful when feedback has a clear route to decision makers and produces documented responses.

A consistent lesson in the reviewed literature is that No single indicator adequately represents comprehension and vocabulary. Quantitative measures of reach should be interpreted together with evidence about quality, burden, safety, cultural fit, and continuity. This mixed monitoring logic prevents high enrollment or message counts from being mistaken for meaningful access or effective use.

When the evidence is read in relation to rural and low-income settings that comprehension and vocabulary cannot be treated as a stand-alone technical matter. It is connected to household resources, institutional routines, local infrastructure, and the quality of communication among public agencies, service providers, and communities.

From an equity perspective that The central analytical proposition of this review is prolonged school closures can deepen reading difficulties by reducing explicit

instruction, guided practice, oral interaction, access to texts, and timely diagnosis. This proposition directs attention away from individual blame and toward the conditions that enable or constrain practical action.

Home Literacy Inequality

When the evidence is read in relation to rural and low-income settings that Differences between urban and rural locations, secure and precarious households, and well-resourced and under-resourced institutions caution against universal solutions. Average access figures can conceal shared devices, unstable signals, indirect costs, language barriers, disability, and care responsibilities.

From an equity perspective that The literature therefore supports a layered response: establish a minimum service that reaches everyone; add targeted assistance for groups facing higher barriers; monitor participation and unintended effects; and revise implementation using local feedback.

The evidence available through 2021 indicates that Implementation should also be judged over time. A measure that solves an immediate problem may create fatigue, hidden household costs, privacy risks, or declining participation when maintained without adjustment. Periodic review is therefore part of the intervention rather than an administrative afterthought.

Across policy reports and early pandemic scholarship that Local actors are essential sources of practical knowledge. Teachers, parents, barangay workers, vendors, farmers, youth, and community organizations can identify constraints that are invisible in national plans. Participation is most useful when feedback has a clear route to decision makers and produces documented responses.

A consistent lesson in the reviewed literature is that No single indicator adequately represents home literacy inequality. Quantitative measures of reach should be interpreted together with evidence about quality, burden, safety, cultural fit, and continuity. This mixed monitoring logic prevents high enrollment or message counts from being mistaken for meaningful access or effective use.

When the evidence is read in relation to rural and low-income settings that home literacy inequality cannot be treated as a stand-alone technical matter. It is connected to household resources, institutional routines, local infrastructure, and the quality of communication among public agencies, service providers, and communities.

From an equity perspective that The central analytical proposition of this review is prolonged school closures can deepen reading difficulties by reducing explicit instruction, guided practice, oral interaction, access to texts, and timely diagnosis. This proposition directs attention away from individual blame and toward the conditions that enable or constrain practical action.

The evidence available through 2021 indicates that Early COVID-19 responses were necessarily rapid, but speed sometimes produced fragmented arrangements.

Programs were strongest when objectives were prioritized, roles were explicit, feedback moved in both directions, and low-technology alternatives remained available.

Screening And Targeted Support

From an equity perspective that The literature therefore supports a layered response: establish a minimum service that reaches everyone; add targeted assistance for groups facing higher barriers; monitor participation and unintended effects; and revise implementation using local feedback.

The evidence available through 2021 indicates that Implementation should also be judged over time. A measure that solves an immediate problem may create fatigue, hidden household costs, privacy risks, or declining participation when maintained without adjustment. Periodic review is therefore part of the intervention rather than an administrative afterthought.

Across policy reports and early pandemic scholarship that Local actors are essential sources of practical knowledge. Teachers, parents, barangay workers, vendors, farmers, youth, and community organizations can identify constraints that are invisible in national plans. Participation is most useful when feedback has a clear route to decision makers and produces documented responses.

A consistent lesson in the reviewed literature is that No single indicator adequately represents screening and targeted support. Quantitative measures of reach should be interpreted together with evidence about quality, burden, safety, cultural fit, and continuity. This mixed monitoring logic prevents high enrollment or message counts from being mistaken for meaningful access or effective use.

When the evidence is read in relation to rural and low-income settings that screening and targeted support cannot be treated as a stand-alone technical matter. It is connected to household resources, institutional routines, local infrastructure, and the quality of communication among public agencies, service providers, and communities.

From an equity perspective that The central analytical proposition of this review is prolonged school closures can deepen reading difficulties by reducing explicit instruction, guided practice, oral interaction, access to texts, and timely diagnosis. This proposition directs attention away from individual blame and toward the conditions that enable or constrain practical action.

The evidence available through 2021 indicates that Early COVID-19 responses were necessarily rapid, but speed sometimes produced fragmented arrangements. Programs were strongest when objectives were prioritized, roles were explicit, feedback moved in both directions, and low-technology alternatives remained available.

Across policy reports and early pandemic scholarship that Differences between urban and rural locations, secure and precarious households, and well-resourced and under-resourced institutions caution against universal solutions. Average access figures can conceal shared devices, unstable signals, indirect costs, language barriers, disability, and care responsibilities.

Table 1

Summary of Thematic Findings

Theme	Interpretive finding
Foundational Reading Disruption	Foundational Reading Disruption is shaped by interacting material, organizational, social, and informational conditions; isolated technical solutions are therefore insufficient.
Comprehension And Vocabulary	Comprehension And Vocabulary is shaped by interacting material, organizational, social, and informational conditions; isolated technical solutions are therefore insufficient.
Home Literacy Inequality	Home Literacy Inequality is shaped by interacting material, organizational, social, and informational conditions; isolated technical solutions are therefore insufficient.
Screening And Targeted Support	Screening And Targeted Support is shaped by interacting material, organizational, social, and informational conditions; isolated technical solutions are therefore insufficient.

Discussion

Taken together, the themes support the conclusion that prolonged school closures can deepen reading difficulties by reducing explicit instruction, guided practice, oral interaction, access to texts, and timely diagnosis. The most important implication is that a crisis response should be assessed by reach, usability, continuity, and fairness, not merely by whether a program or platform exists.

A useful framework contains four layers. The first is a universal minimum: clear information, a reachable service channel, accessible materials, and a known point of contact. The second is targeted support based on observed barriers rather than broad labels. The third is a feedback loop that detects nonparticipation, confusion, burden, and exclusion early. The fourth is adaptive governance, through which local actors can modify delivery while preserving standards and accountability.

This framework also clarifies responsibility. Individuals retain agency, but institutions shape the feasible choice set. Recommendations that require equipment, connectivity, transport, protective supplies, advanced literacy, or unpaid time must specify how these resources will be made available. Otherwise, policy can unintentionally transfer costs to the least-resourced households.

Equity should be operationalized through disaggregated monitoring and alternative routes. Rural residence is not itself a uniform condition: communities differ in signal coverage, road access, language, livelihoods, local leadership, and proximity to services. Planning should therefore combine national minimum standards with barangay- and school-level diagnosis.

Finally, emergency measures should leave durable capacity. Investments in teacher support, public communication, local supply chains, psychosocial referral, accessible learning materials, and data governance remain valuable beyond a single outbreak. Resilience is not a return to the previous condition; it is the capacity to continue essential functions while learning and adapting.

Recommended Response and Validation Cycle

Table 2

Priority Actions Before Local Implementation or Effectiveness Research

P riorit y	Action	Evidence produced
1	Establish a minimum service standard that can be met without assuming continuous broadband access or high household purchasing power.	Minimum-service specification
2	Map barriers locally and provide targeted support for households, workers, learners, and enterprises facing compounded disadvantages.	Local barrier and equity map
3	Use redundant communication channels, plain language, local languages where appropriate, and a documented method for correcting misinformation.	Communication and correction log
4	Create routine feedback and referral mechanisms so that implementation problems are visible before they become exclusion or harm.	Participation and referral record

P riorit y	Action	Evidence produced
5	Protect privacy, dignity, labor rights, cultural rights, and accessibility while collecting only the data necessary for response.	Rights and accessibility review
6	Review policies at defined intervals and publish the basis for revisions, including limitations and unresolved evidence gaps.	Revision record and research agenda

Implications for Future Research

Future empirical work should begin with a transparent local theory of change and collect evidence at more than one level. Household or individual surveys can describe access and experience, but they should be complemented by administrative records, interviews, observation, or implementation data. Sampling frames must include people who are difficult to reach digitally, since online-only recruitment can reproduce the very exclusion being studied. Researchers should predefine outcomes, document missing data, report subgroup differences responsibly, and avoid interpreting cross-sectional association as causation.

Longitudinal and comparative designs would help distinguish short-term emergency reactions from durable institutional change. Studies should report not only whether an intervention was offered but whether intended users could access, understand, afford, and sustain it. Participatory approaches can improve relevance, particularly in Indigenous, rural, and livelihood-dependent communities, provided that consent, data governance, benefit sharing, and community authority are respected.

Conclusion

The literature available through 2021 provides a coherent basis for understanding reading difficulties among learners during prolonged school closures. Its central lesson is that prolonged school closures can deepen reading difficulties by reducing explicit instruction, guided practice, oral interaction, access to texts, and timely diagnosis. Effective responses combine material provision, capable institutions, trusted communication, meaningful participation, and continuous learning. These conclusions offer a defensible foundation for policy and future empirical research, but they do not substitute for locally collected data or author verification.

References

Barron Rodriguez, M., Cobo, C., Muñoz-Najar, A., & Sánchez Ciarrusta, I. (2021). Remote learning during the global school lockdown: Multi-country lessons. World Bank.

- Bozkurt, A., et al. (2020). A global outlook to the interruption of education due to COVID-19 pandemic. *Asian Journal of Distance Education*, 15(1), 1-126.
- Hodges, C., Moore, S., Lockee, B., Trust, T., & Bond, A. (2020). The difference between emergency remote teaching and online learning. *EDUCAUSE Review*.
- UNESCO. (2020). Education in the time of COVID-19. UNESCO.
- UNESCO. (2020). Ensuring effective distance learning during COVID-19 disruption: Guidance for teachers. UNESCO.
- UNICEF. (2020). COVID-19: Are children able to continue learning during school closures? UNICEF.
- World Bank. (2020). Philippines digital economy report 2020: A better normal under COVID-19. World Bank.
- World Bank. (2021). Impacts of COVID-19 on households in the Philippines: Results from the Philippines COVID-19 households survey. World Bank.
- World Health Organization. (2020). Risk communication and community engagement readiness and response to coronavirus disease (COVID-19). WHO.
- World Health Organization. (2020). Mental health and psychosocial considerations during the COVID-19 outbreak. WHO.
- International Labour Organization. (2020). ILO monitor: COVID-19 and the world of work. ILO.
- Food and Agriculture Organization. (2020). COVID-19 and the risk to food supply chains: How to respond? FAO.
- Brooks, S. K., et al. (2020). The psychological impact of quarantine and how to reduce it. *The Lancet*, 395, 912-920.
- DepEd. (2020). DepEd Order No. 12, s. 2020: Adoption of the Basic Education Learning Continuity Plan. Department of Education, Philippines.
- Republic of the Philippines. (2010). Republic Act No. 10121: Philippine Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Act of 2010.
- United Nations Office for Disaster Risk Reduction. (2015). Sendai framework for disaster risk reduction 2015-2030. UNDRR.